

NO SUNSET ON THIS BOULEVARD

Veteran actors are getting ready for their close-ups as soap stars on television and powerful oldsters on the big screen

■ By Kimi Dangor and Swati Mathur

He jived, jammed and danced his way back into the hearts of television audiences. And even though Jumping Jack Jeetendra insists he only took on the task of playing celebrity judge on *Jhalak Dikhhla Jaa 2* at the insistence of his daughter, soap queen Ekta Kapoor, the veteran

actor's twinkle toes left many of the contestants discoed out. "I am doing something that I truly enjoy," says Jeetendra, his trademark twist and timing still very much in place.

And even while the *Himmatwala* made his courageous comeback on TV, Hindi cinema's original hunk Dharmendra returned to films with a hat-trick of performances in home production *Apne*, *Life in A... Metro* and *Johnny Gaddaar*. For these heart-throbs of the flirtatious '60s and irrepressible '70s increasingly grabbing film roles and television airtime, it

JEETENDRA 65

He shook a leg in a cameo for *Om Shanti Om* and played judge on *Jhalak Dikhhla Jaa 2*. Now his daughter Ekta has convinced him to play Thakur in her Bhojpuri remake of *Sholay*.

SANTANU SARKAR



DHARMENDRA 72

After *Apne*, *Life in A... Metro* and *Johnny Gaddaar*, cinema's original hunk will be seen in Jahn timer Barua's *Har Pal*.



RISHI KAPOOR 55

After *Fanaa* (2006) and *Namaste London* (2007), the evergreen romantic hero will be seen with Rekha in Raj Kanwar's *Sadiyaan*.

looks like there are no goodbyes. While one-time sex symbol Vinod Khanna returned from Osho-induced oblivion with the role of a mob boss in Vishram Sawant's *Risk* last year, he has now taken the patriarch route to TV with *Mere Apne* on 9X, where he has abandoned his macho image and donned a dhoti-kurta to play the gray-haired Khashinath Pandey.

Television, which was once seen as a last attempt at fame for fading film stars (remember Amitabh Bachchan's rise from bankruptcy with *Kaun Banega Crorepati?*), now offers respectable avenues for the old guard. "I do not mind television since it is all about connecting with my fans," says Khanna, who, at 60, is getting a taste of teetering time-tables with a five-hour commute between his home and the studio, followed by a 10-hour shift.